goods? Given that the current Indo-US trade is $212 billion or so, how will we honour our intent over five years, as has been mentioned?

We have done a very careful analysis. Many American products have a competitive edge over those from other nations. Even today, we import $300 billion worth of such products from around the world and the need is growing rapidly. For example, imports of ICT [information and communication technology] products have grown by as much as 20 per cent in some years. We estimate that in the next five years, we will need to import about $2 trillion worth of energy products—including crude oil and LPG—precious metals, ICT products, hi-tech semiconductor chips, coking coal, aircraft and aircraft parts. I see no reason why, in that $2 trillion pie, Indian importers should not have the option to import from the US. Our approach for products that we need to buy anyway is very simple: the more the merrier. I would welcome competition among global suppliers so that India gets the best deal, it is good for Indian consumers and the economy, and spurs growth.

Q. What about an agreement on mobility, given the tough situation we have been facing after Trump in his second term has imposed curbs on H-1B visas and made them more costly?

Look, any nation can lay down rules or laws, including restrictions on H-1B visa-holders. I don't think this will impact our relationship or trade potential. On the contrary, it'll be good for India. Let me explain why. Today, India has 1,800-plus global capability centres (GCCs). We don't have to be sitting in an office in New York or Tokyo to do things that can be done offshore. So, instead of hiring people and sending them to the US at top-dollar salaries, foreign companies can attract top talent by setting up GCCs in India. It will be good for them, helping them become more efficient. And when they come, give jobs to Indians in India, we can be in our homes, with our families and with our cultural identity and family values intact. We pay taxes in India, invest our savings here, consume and create demand in India. It boosts the real estate industry, as well as related ecosystems like restaurants and hotels. The icing on the cake is that we earn more foreign exchange. So, in every respect, this is far better than the nominal remittance a person going and living abroad can send.

Q. What about the other elephant in the room: the deal with the US to stop buying Russian oil in exchange for a waiver of the additional 25 per cent penalty? How do we meet our oil needs now at a reasonable cost?

The foreign ministry handles that subject. We have handled it very admirably, and they have from time to time briefed people about the progress in that respect. So, you can speak to them about it.

Q. We have also agreed to remove or lower our non-tariff barriers. Are we, in some sense, allowing America to determine these?

It is a win-win for us. We want to see India as a modern nation which engages with the world on equal terms. We would like our customers—1.4 billion Indians—to also enjoy the same high quality the world is enjoying. Prime Minister Modi has from the day he took charge talked about zero effect, zero defect. In a recent *Mann Ki Baat* episode too, he said that India must become a quality-conscious nation. We are very clear that we should develop a Brand India that is recognised the world over for its high quality both for goods and services.

"We have a demographic dividend of people under 30, for 30 years, to take us to $30 trillion. I call it the power of 30-30-30"

"FTAs by UPA governments made a fundamental mistake: they were made with our competitors, who were developing or less developed countries"

Q. How do these deals benefit the common man? What is their employment potential and in which areas?

Indians will benefit in every sector of the economy, whether it's labour-oriented sectors like textiles, apparel, shoes, leather goods, sportswear, or fishermen, farmers, skilled workers, handicrafts or handlooms. The deals provide a big boost to make in India and will therefore create substantial job and investment opportunities. They will also enable our startups to attract investments, while providing stability and predictability.

Q. Could you put a number to the kind of jobs that will be created?

Well, numbers are up to the people and investors. If our exporters grab this opportunity, the sky is the limit. You could get millions of jobs. Also, it's up to us to come out of our comfort zones and grab the global opportunities PM Modi is opening through his astute management of the Indian economy. PM Modi has, particularly in the past six months, powered a reform express, which is going at breakneck speed. And our FTAs and international engagements are an integral part of his reform and transform agenda, because if we don't reform, don't make it easier for companies to do business, don't make the lives of the common man easier, don't decriminalise the onerous provisions of law, don't reduce the process, procedure and compliance burden, we will not become a developed nation by 2047. This is the collective commitment of 140 crore Indians. A Viksit Bharat by 2047 is non-negotiable. ■